# ‘Great Attrition’ or ‘Great Attraction’?

The choice is yours

**MBA Article Summary**

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# Executive Summary

Employee attrition reached a record pace during the pandemic, and the authors argue that many organizations misunderstood its real causes.

Employees were seeking more than compensation: they wanted to feel valued, connected, included, and supported by their organizations and managers.

The central employer–employee disconnect was relational versus transactional: employers emphasized pay and practical issues, while employees emphasized belonging and appreciation.

The article's strategic message is simple: listen to employees, redesign the employee experience, and turn the Great Attrition into a Great Attraction.

# The Great Attrition: Scale and Research Evidence

**19M+**
U.S. workers quit since April 2021

**40%**
employees at least somewhat likely to quit

**53%**
employers reporting greater voluntary turnover

**64%**
expecting turnover to stay elevated/increase

The employee survey covered 5,774 working-age people across Australia, Canada, Singapore, the United Kingdom, and the United States.

The employer survey covered 250 talent-focused managers across large and midsize organizations.

The article concludes that the Great Attrition is widespread, likely to persist, and not confined to one industry.

# Likelihood of Leaving by Industry




Page 3's Exhibit 1 shows that attrition risk was substantial across all surveyed industries, with leisure and hospitality highest at 47%.

# A Key Warning: Employees Were Willing to Quit Without Another Job

**36%**
of recent quitters had no new job in hand

**64%**
of likely quitters said they would leave without a job

**40%**
of U.S. quitters did so without another job

This behavior signals that dissatisfaction could outweigh the security of having another job lined up.

Healthcare and social-assistance workers were particularly affected: 42% of those who quit did so without a new job.

The authors interpret this as evidence that employers may have underestimated the depth of employees' pandemic-era strain.

# The Central Problem: Employers Misread Why Employees Leave

## Employees' top reasons

Did not feel valued by the organization — 54%

Did not feel valued by the manager — 52%

Did not feel a sense of belonging — 51%

Relational factors were especially important.

## Employers' assumptions

Compensation

Work–life balance

Poor physical and emotional health

Employers tended to emphasize transactional factors more than employees did.

# Relational Needs vs. Transactional Fixes

## Transactional response

Raise pay

Add financial perks

Offer thank-you bonuses

## Relational response

Make people feel valued

Build belonging and trust

Create meaningful connection, purpose and shared identity

**ey insight: Compensation matters, but compensation alone can make the relationship feel transactional rather than genuinely supportive**

# Remote Work Changes the Retention Equation

**65%**
of employees unlikely to quit cited liking where they lived as a reason to stay

**87%**
of people taking jobs in another city/state were allowed to work remotely

**13%**
had to relocate for the new job

Expanded remote-work options create ‘location-agnostic’ opportunities that can attract employees who previously seemed satisfied.

Organizations that mishandle hybrid transitions—or refuse flexibility altogether—risk triggering avoidable exits.

The article does not present remote work as a complete solution; it emphasizes balancing flexibility with connection and community.

# Leadership Implications

Develop empathy: leaders need a deeper understanding of what employees are experiencing.

Pair empathy with action: listening without changing practices will not address attrition.

Address toxic or unsupportive leadership: employees may leave managers and organizations even without another job secured.

Build hybrid leadership capability: managers need skills for leading distributed and virtual teams.

Re-examine organizational culture: pre-pandemic weaknesses may become more visible when work arrangements change.

# Turning Attrition into Attraction: Management Actions

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Listen systematically** | Include employees in designing the response; do not decide from the executive suite alone. |
| 2 | **Strengthen managers** | Put the right people in the right roles and build hybrid/virtual leadership capabilities. |
| 3 | **Redesign benefits** | Align benefits with actual priorities, including family-care needs. |
| 4 | **Create career paths** | Offer recognition, advancement and development opportunities. |
| 5 | **Build community** | Combine flexibility with meaningful connection, trust and shared identity. |

# Illustrative Practices Mentioned in the Article

## Family & career support

45% of recent quitters cited family-care needs as an influential factor.

The article highlights childcare, nursing services and family-focused benefits.

Patagonia is cited for retaining nearly 100% of new mothers with on-site childcare and parent benefits.

## Recognition & community

Waffle House is cited for multiple levels within grill roles, creating visible progression.

‘Staycation’ packages and shared Slack activities helped employees connect.

Coffee-chat incentives were used to expand employees’ internal networks.

# MBA / Organizational Behavior Learning Points

Employee turnover is not merely a compensation problem; it is also a relationship, leadership, culture and meaning problem.

Managers are critical ‘moments of truth’ in the employee experience: feeling valued by the manager was one of the strongest reported reasons for staying/leaving.

Hybrid work changes the psychological and social contract between employees and organizations.

Retention requires understanding employee needs before designing interventions.

Strategic HR and OB should treat employees as whole people—not simply as labor or human capital transactions.

# Class Discussion / Case Questions

If you were the HR head, what would you investigate before increasing salaries or bonuses?

Which is more difficult for managers: providing flexibility or creating belonging in a hybrid environment? Why?

How can an organization measure whether employees genuinely feel valued?

What leadership behaviors could convert an employee’s intention to quit into an intention to stay?

Design a 90-day ‘Great Attraction’ action plan for an organization facing high voluntary turnover.

# The choice is yours.

**Listen → Understand → Act**

Move beyond transactional fixes.

Build value, belonging, flexibility, purpose and connection.

That is how attrition can become attraction.